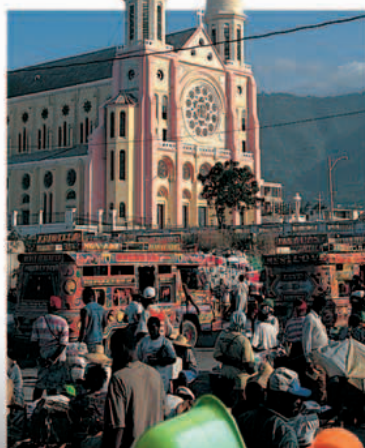




THE ORIGINAL INHABITANTS OF THE WEST INDIES WERE the CRÉOLES

TROPICAL MIX



COLORFUL CAPITAL

In Port au Prince, capital of Haiti, the towering Roman Catholic cathedral is clearly European in style. The exterior, though, is painted bright tropical pink, which forms a perfect backdrop to the vibrant cityscape constantly moving around it.

Best of both worlds

Créole society reflects both French and African culture. Buildings tend to be European in style, with distinctively tropical touches. On the whole, clothing has a conventional Western look that is often interpreted in brilliant sunshine hues. And the Créole language is a unique and expressive blend of African sentence structure and French vocabulary.

SPECIAL DAY

Decked out in frothy white dresses with gloves and veils, these young girls in St. Lucia pose proudly for the camera on the day they take their first communion. Catholicism is the dominant religion in the French West Indies, and people take great pride in observing its rites.



SPIRITS OF THE PAST

A follower of the Vodun religion performs a ritual dance. Strongly associated with Haiti, Vodun arrived with West-African slaves. Like Christianity, it is spirit based, with one supreme God and many lesser dieties (Vodun means "spirit"). Its traditions bear little relation to those of the bizarre fictional cult of Voodoo. ("Voodoo" is an older spelling of Vodun.)



CASH AND CARRY

Many Créole people are very poor, and women regularly walk for days to sell their wares at the nearest market, bearing heavy loads on their head all the way. These Haitian peddlers in Port au Prince have high hopes of selling their precariously stacked supplies of plastic basins and household towels.

